Chanukah 5784

חנוכה! The מצוה of חנוכה is מהדרין מן המהדרין. We follow the opinion of בית הלל, and each day we add another candle. On the first night, we light one candle; on the second night, two; and so on. I saw a fantastic, גיוואלדיק insight on this from R' Elimelech Biderman (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), he should live and be well. He explains that the עבודה of contemplating and reflecting on the חסדים of הקדוש ברוך הוא is not so difficult when you learn how to do it. Just as we add another candle each day, so too we must reflect daily on the חסדים of Hashem.

Consider the קרבן תודה. This קרבן, which represents and expresses our appreciation for הקדוש ברוך הוא's kindness to us in every way, is unique. Unlike a קרבן שלמים, which may be consumed over two days and one intervening night, the קרבן תודה is eaten only on the day it is brought and the following night. Why is that?

The חידושי הרי"ם explains that the קרבן תודה is restricted to one day because each new day brings its own reason for expressing thanks. Every day has its own נס. One who lives with awareness and pays attention to the חסדים that flow from Hashem will see this clearly.

R' Biderman shared a story about a Yid in ארץ ישראל who lost his father at a young age. His mother, left without a means to support the family, wanted him to leave ישיבה and go to work. Unsure of what to do, he approached his ראש ישיבה, the Manchester צדיק, R' Yehuda Zev Segal for guidance. R' Segal advised him to go to work but gave him a תנאי - a condition to carry with him.

"Every night in מעריב, when you say the words in davening, וְעַל נִסֶּיךָ שֶׁבְּכָל יוֹם עִמָּנוּ, 'the miracles You perform for us every day,'" he instructed, "think of one נס that you merited that day."

The Yid told R' Biderman that 40 years have passed since that moment, and not a single day has gone by where he struggled to find a נס to reflect upon. This simple condition given by R' Segal not only helped him live with an awareness of Hashem's חסדים, but also transformed his תפילות into something much more powerful.

This is a lesson we can take from חנוכה and apply throughout the year. We love חנוכה - wouldn't it be wonderful to carry its message with us every day? The way to do that is to live with an awareness of Hashem's חסדים. This can be achieved by internalizing the lesson of חנוכה: recognizing the significance of each and every day. Just as we add another candle each night of חנוכה, showing how every day has its own unique importance, we should adopt this perspective in our daily lives. Like R' Segal taught, take a moment each day to think about one נס you merited that day. If we do this properly, we can extend the spirit of חנוכה into the rest of the year.

https://youtu.be/1QvAq04e_rY